

OPPOSITION HUDDLE Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge with INDIA bloc partners addresses the media after an alliance meeting, New Delhi, Apr. 15

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INDIA in Retreat

A COALITION THAT CAN STILL HOLD THE LINE IN PARLIAMENT IS STEADILY LOSING GROUND ACROSS THE STATES. ITS SHRINKING MAP EXPOSES FRACTURES IN STRATEGY, LEADERSHIP AND IDENTITY

By Kaushik Deka

When Opposition parties gathered in the muggy summer of 2023 to christen itself the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance, or INDIA, they governed 11 states. The Congress held Rajasthan, Himachal Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Karnataka. The Trinamool Congress was firmly in power in West Bengal; so was the Communist Party of India (Marxist)-led Left Democratic Front in Kerala. A Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam-led front ruled Tamil Nadu, the Aam Aadmi Party held the reins in Delhi and Punjab, the Congress-Left, Janata Dal (United)-Rashtriya Janata Dal mahagathbandhan governed Bihar, and a Jharkhand Mukti Morcha-Congress-RJD combine was in power in Jharkhand.

Cut to the summer of 2026. The map has shrunk by more than half. In the assembly polls since the 2024 general election, Maharashtra, Haryana, Bihar, Delhi—and now West Bengal and Assam—have all been retained or wrested anew by the BJP. Mamata Banerjee, the Trinamool's redoubtable matriarch, is out of power for the first time since 2011. DMK chief M.K. Stalin has lost Tamil Nadu to a film star. The Left, having lost Kerala, finds itself without a single CM for the first time since 1977.

Bengal and Tamil Nadu together send 81 MPs to the Lok Sabha—nearly a sixth of the House—and were the very turfs where the Bharatiya Janata Party had been decisively blocked in 2024. In the